Youngsters

By Brian Dykstra

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Dear Abby: I'm a 20-year-old junior in college and I've been talking online with my professor a lot. He started hinting that he was interested in me. One day, after class, we kissed and talked about having sex. He says that I'm mature for my age and that we just had an instant connection. If it wasn't for his obligations (he's married and has kids), he said he would marry me. I'm in love with him now. Still, sometimes I think that maybe he's done this kind of thing before or that he will in the future. Is this a mistake?*

ACTOR: *Youngsters by Brian Dykstra*

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Paula sits, waiting and working on some paperwork. Gordon enters, as if looking for Paula.

GORDON: There you are.

PAULA: You mean here in my office?

GORDON: Right.

PAULA: OK.

GORDON: I've come to a decision.

PAULA: Hold on a minute.

GORDON: I've decided.

PAULA: I hear you, but it seems quick.

GORDON: I know what I'm doing.

PAULA: I'm sure you do, but I want you to think about it some more.

GORDON: I don't need to.

PAULA: "Fools rush in ... "

GORDON: Do you somehow know what I've decided?

PAULA: No.

GORDON: Then how do you know I'm rushing in?

PAULA: Are you?

GORDON: ... Not really the point.

PAULA: You're not going to send it.

GORDON: Yes, I am.

PAULA: Why?

GORDON: He can't do what he's doing. It's wrong.

PAULA: Wrong? OK, but what are you hoping to get out of sending it?

GORDON: I'm hoping to right this wrong.

PAULA: Yes, fine, but is there nothing about this that's between you and Peter, something about evening up some kind of score?

GORDON: What are you suggesting?

PAULA: He's a very popular teacher.

GORDON: I'm not that shallow.

PAULA: She's a very fetching girl.

GORDON: What am I hearing?

PAULA: Is there part of you that feels the need to get even?

GORDON: Let me be clear, nothing about this is about vengeance.

PAULA: Vengeance? See, that's a surprise. The word I would have used was *revenge.*

GORDON: Is there a substantive difference?

PAULA: Not that I'm aware of. Except for the fact the one you chose is traditionally the domain of The Lord.

GORDON: The Lord? We're talking about The Lord now?

PAULA: In this climate, we'd be fools not to.

GORDON: So, what's your point? Are you making some point with that old, "Vengeance is Mine" is that what you're doing?

PAULA: Yes. "Sayeth The Lord." You have some kind of God complex going on I'm

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not aware of?

GORDON: So, OK, Revenge, then. But, wait, you know what? The truth is, it's not about revenge *or* vengeance. No, it's about justice.

PAULA: That's what you say. But we both know it's not entirely about justice.

GORDON: We do?

PAULA: Sure. Because you just now committed to revenge after not wanting to commit to vengeance. If it was really about justice, you wouldn't feel the need to make the distinction.

GORDON: Stop talking like I'm a student in one of your classes.

PAULA: Forgive me. Occupational hazard. As you well know. But, I've been thinking about it too, about you sending that letter; and what I've arrived at, is you are not sending that letter.

GORDON: What if I do send it?

PAULA: Then I'm going to show you just how cold revenge can get.

GORDON: Are you threatening me?

PAULA: Am I threatening you? You mean when I said, "I'm going to show you how cold revenge can get?"

GORDON: Yeah. Is that some kind of threat?

PAULA: I hate that question. That's like walking in on a family member, balled up in a corner, bleeding from her ears, rocking back and forth, crying so hard, her clothes are wet. You go over, concerned, you lean down, put your hand on her shoulder and ask gently, "Are you OK?" But it's a stupid question, isn't it? Of course she's not OK. Any idiot can see she's not OK. So, let me frame in your question for you, "Am I threatening you?"

GORDON: Of course you are.

PAULA: Of course I am. You know how we could tell? It was when I said, "I'm going to show you how cold revenge can get." See, how could that be anything but a

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threat? I mean, really now, in what context could that possibly be construed as not a threat?

GORDON: So I guess my question is, *why* are you threatening me?

PAULA: Why do you want to send that letter?

GORDON: It's a fundamental transgression. It's clearly wrong. It's so clearly wrong, it's punishable by dismissal, and there's good reason for that. Teachers sleeping with students, what is she, twenty? If that?

PAULA: Just a poor little lamb.

GORDON: It is clearly a violation of the trust she is required to put in her teacher.

PAULA: That big bad wolf.

GORDON: He's taken advantage of that trust.

PAULA: Blah, blah, blah.

GORDON: He has!

PAULA: So, what?

GORDON: So what? What do you mean, so what? We're watching a girl, a child, get put through the kind of emotional ringer that not only isn't fair to her, it might really be damaging.

PAULA: And, what, it takes a village to raise this child?

GORDON: Why are you being -

PAULA: And you're the self-appointed sheriff of all that is moral in our little village?

GORDON: Why this cavalier? You know I'm right.

PAULA: Why did you let it go on so long? Sheriff. You knew he was seeing this girl socially. It wasn't like they were being all that discreet. Why did you let it go on?

GORDON: I thought it was none of my business.

PAULA: What changed?

GORDON: She's in love with him.

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PAULA: And?

GORDON: You see that, right?

PAULA: I do.

GORDON: So, something needs to be done.

PAULA: Not what you propose.

GORDON: Why not?

PAULA: Because if you send that letter, I'm going to hear about it. And when I hear about it, I'm going to compose a remarkably similar letter. But the subject of my letter will be you. I will accuse you, in my letter of having an affair with a student here. But, unlike you, I will sign my name to it and I will stand by it, after I send a copy to your wife.

GORDON: Why would you do that? It's not even true.

PAULA: Will your wife know it isn't true?

GORDON: Yes.

PAULA: How?

GORDON: ... OK, so she won't. Why would you do that?

PAULA: Because she won't know it isn't true. How could she? None of our spouses would. That's the position we're in. All of us. That's how precarious our jobs are. We work with these children, and I take offense at that characterization, children, my ass. These kids don't know what they're doing when they crawl into the sack with a teacher? Please.

GORDON: This one's in over her head.

PAULA: And I feel for the girl. I do. It's sad. So she'll work through her daddy complex, get a better grade than she deserves, and chalk it up to her first tragic affair. If she's lucky, it might even make her a better writer. I've read her work, it couldn't hurt.

GORDON: That's really the way you want to say that?

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PAULA: What position would you have me take? You want to make this a thing? There are hundreds of students coming through here every year. You really feel that secure you're not going to meet one down the road who pushes all your buttons?

GORDON: Of course not! You mean have an affair with a student? Of course not!

PAULA: If your letter gets sent, and Pete gets dismissed because of it, you will have demonstrated to these children just how much power they possess. Even if he doesn't get dismissed. These students will realize an anonymous letter accusing a teacher of marital infidelity, or of seducing (or being seduced) by a student throws this administration into a tizzy. You think we won't have to deal with a spate of accusations that might touch any one of us?

GORDON: You're having one, too.

PAULA: Don't be ridiculous.

GORDON: But you've had one?

PAULA: Who hasn't?

GORDON: I haven't.

PAULA: You're young yet, give yourself another semester. And so what? It's the pitiful, worst-kept secret of higher education. Hopefully higher education. And, I'm saying we're all at risk. Even you. Even if you're innocent. The rule exists so that if a student wants to bring charges herself, she (or he) has a viable option. But they have to bring it on themselves. The scrutiny, the questions, the innuendo, the public humiliation of having accused, they have to deal with the fallout themselves.

GORDON: So, the victim gets the blame?

PAULA: Victim? No. Other students need to see it's nothing to trifle with. Your letter outs this kid against her will and other students who are in some

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post teenage competition for the attention of a part-time adjunct, figure out how to get rid of that competition by sending letters accusing all kinds of things. The whole cachet of sexual harassment has finally, mercifully faded a bit. Let's not revisit it. Let's not turn this girl into the first lemming in line.

GORDON: Who are you protecting?

PAULA: You. Obviously. Me. The rest of the faculty. All of us.

GORDON: And this girl?

PAULA: It's a dalliance with a teacher. She's in over her head. Hopefully, she'll drag Peter into some emotional disaster, as well. Hopefully there will be some cost to him for his behavior. Hopefully, when some dark-eyed beauty comes along who reminds you of your first crush, you'll remember how you made room for a fellow teacher a few years back, and hope precedent makes room for you, so some spiteful sculptured prick doesn't put you through the kind of humiliating question & answer -! ... And ... Perhaps, I've said too much. If you do the research, you will find a slight bump in the road of my ivory tower career that lands me at this liberal arts institution at this stage in my life, rather than the slightly more elevated position I had envisioned for myself And, that being the case, let's be honest, these empty-headed children of leisure who kill brain cells with ecstasy and hip-hop while dressing like whores and desperately search for husbands rather than educations, what's the only thing most of them are good for if not the occasional roll in the hay?

GORDON: Are you serious?

PAULA: How could I be? You want revenge, look for it somewhere else.

GORDON: I don't want revenge.

PAULA: Good. That's safer. Cleaner. Don't want revenge. Look what happens to a

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person when you do.

GORDON: ... This is someone different.

PAULA: And your point.

GORDON: ... What do you have against her?

PAULA: Specifically? I don't know. I suppose I'm aghast she had the bad taste to choose Peter. As for the rest of them: Now that I'm to live out my days at a second-tier educational institution nowhere near a population center that supports world-class culture or art, not enough of these frat boys want me, anymore. That's what I have against her. But, not to worry. I'm sure I'll get over it.

(Gordon lingers a moment. Paula gets back to work. Gordon leaves the room. Paula doesn't even look up. She just continues working.)

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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